

Seafloor fish

An amazing variety of fish live on or near shallow coastal seabeds. Many are specialized for seabed life, with heavy bodies that weigh them down so they can lie on the bottom. They are often flattened and so well camouflaged that they are almost invisible when they lie still. Some hunt for seafloor animals such as crabs and clams. Others are ambush predators that wait for prey to come within attacking range.



▲ **RED GURNARD**
Sensitive fin rays beneath its head allow this north Atlantic hunter to locate hidden prey.

AMBUSH KILLERS

Some predatory fish lie half-buried on the seabed, waiting for other fish to swim close enough to catch. An anglerfish tempts prey within range using a wriggling lure, like a worm dangling over its enormous mouth. Stargazers have eyes on the tops of their heads for targeting victims, which they dart up to and seize with their sharp teeth.



▲ **MARBLED STARGAZER**
Also known as the pop-eyed fish, the venomous stargazer lies in wait with just its eyes and upward-facing mouth showing above the sand.

TOUCH SENSITIVE

Soft seabeds are home to a variety of burrowing animals, including small crabs and marine worms. Although they are hidden from sight, some fish such as gurnards are able to find them. These fish have specially adapted pectoral fins with sensitive fingerlike fin rays that can feel for prey buried in the sand as they swim slowly over the bottom.

ROCKY REFUGES

On rocky seabeds, many bottom-dwelling fish take refuge in rock crevices and gaps between boulders. These offer small fish protection from their enemies, but they also make perfect hideouts for ambush predators. Some fish such as moray eels may spend most of their lives in one rocky refuge, leaving it only to snatch passing prey.

◀ **MORAY EELS**
These powerful hunters have very sharp teeth for seizing and holding on to slippery, struggling prey.

